Mission and home-base games: lessons for the stronghold loop

Study, 2026-10-16. Not a decision document: anything we adopt goes to `docs/decisions.md`. Report title: "Build a home that thanks you back".

Where the project stood

- **Hook decided today (user):** community and helping. A fallen world; one mouse goes on missions (often rescues) and returns to a ruined abbey-like stronghold that the rescued move into and rebuild; rescued folk give abilities, buffs, or join as AI-ally adventurers; missions bring gear and building resources; mission -> home -> mission; co-op heroes help each other.
- **Last tasks merged:** T021 multi-hero engine (code), A013 Mouse Fighter to the rig standard (art).
- **In progress / queued:** T022 AI ally + revive + potion toss, T023 new Mouse Fighter import (code). Art idle, waiting on this design.
- **Why this study:** the user asked for research on games with a missions + home-base structure (beat 'em ups or not): trends, lessons, things to avoid, and animal-world crossovers, before designing the home loop.

The mission -> home -> mission loop works best when **the home is made of people rather than menus**, and every rescue changes something you can see or play. Each praised precedent shows one part of this. Hades gives every vendor a voice that comments on your last run. Bastion raises one building for each mission goal. Moonlighter's empty town fills up as you succeed. Children of Morta tells its story through family scenes at home. The failures all go wrong in a few predictable ways: too many currencies (Hades II), permanent power you must grind before combat is fun (Absolum, Children of Morta, Rogue Legacy 2), base chores that run while you're away or block the story (Cult of the Lamb, Ni no Kuni II), and chores that undercut a warm theme (Winter Burrow, 5/10). Absolum (2025) is the closest genre neighbour, a co-op brawler roguelite. Its hub reads to reviewers as a levelling shop, and its progression gets marked down as grind-gated. That leaves a real gap for a beat 'em up whose home is warm, full of people and quick to visit. The tone is open too: animal-world action games lean "cute but creepy" or grim (Tails of Iron, Cult of the Lamb), and the clearest sincerely heroic precedent found is a tabletop RPG, Mouse Guard. For this project, the abbey should be a single walkable room of rescued folk. Each rescue unlocks a new *option* (a vendor, a move, an ally) more often than a stat. There should be one building currency plus a small gear set. AI allies get clear support roles and must survive bosses. Nothing at home should ever decay, tick down or gate the next mission.

Hubs succeed as households, not shops

The best-loved hubs make each vendor a character with something to say. In the House of Hades, Zagreus returns to a Great Hall where Hades, Cerberus, Nyx, Megaera and the House Contractor stand around, and new rooms such as the Lounge open after a few runs (Prima Games). GameSpot traces this "evolving hub" back to Bastion, noting that each return brings "new dialogue … new weapons, hub areas, and upgrades" (GameSpot). Bastion has the cleanest rebuild mechanic in the set: **each core recovered on a mission adds one of six structures to the Bastion**, and the survivors you meet come back to live there (Wikipedia: Bastion). Moonlighter turns the same idea into a town. Rynoka starts "almost empty," and as you progress "more and more NPCs came to my village," with funded

shopkeepers opening a blacksmith and a potion shop (RPG Site). Rogue Legacy does it with the blacksmith, enchantress and architect, who arrive as you spend gold (Wikipedia: Rogue Legacy).

Recruitment-heavy RPGs show how to scale this to a large cast. Suikoden's headquarters are "abandoned, monster-infested castles which turn into bustling communities when captured," built around 108 recruits but **only about six party slots** (Wikipedia: Suikoden). Most recruits therefore serve some function other than fighting. In Suikoden II they also become stats on the war map (Wikipedia: Suikoden II). In Ni no Kuni II, "you can only craft certain items and research certain bonuses after you recruit specific citizens" (PC Gamer). Dark Cloud 2 asks you to "invite the right type of craftsmen" to run buildings, and residents state preferences such as a botanist wanting a house next to trees (GameCritics; Dark Cloud wiki). Across these games recruits fall into three types: **service recruits** who open a vendor or facility, **passive recruits** whose effect is a number, and a minority of **party recruits**. That maps directly onto the project's "abilities, buffs, or join as adventurers."

The emotional case comes from Spiritfarer's creative director Nicolas Guérin. Most of the team disliked keeping spirits' houses on the boat, and he kept them anyway because "you build them for others" (Pocket Tactics). That line is the project's theme. In a world where folk stopped helping each other, building a kitchen *for* the rescued cook is the act of helping, so the build menu carries the theme too. Children of Morta shows how much warmth a home alone can create. Its cramped family house is called "one of the most enchanting hubs ever seen in video games," and the game "makes you care more about these people than your next permanent upgrade" (Wireframe).

The art cost of visible growth can stay small. Darkest Dungeon's Hamlet buildings start "dark and run down" and repaint subtly brighter as they're upgraded (Darkest Dungeon wiki), and players still read it as progress. Suikoden uses a few staged HQ levels rather than continuous change (PlayStation LifeStyle). Free placement, as in Spiritfarer's stackable grid, Dark Cloud's Georama and Dragon Quest Builders 2, costs far more art and tooling, and nothing in the research suggests a brawler needs it. Fixed building slots with a ruined and a restored sprite, plus each resident's standee idling near their building, give most of the payoff for about two sprites per building.

Returning home must reward failure, not tax it

Supergiant's stated goal was to "take the sting out of failure," and writer Greg Kasavin has said all their games are "concerned with this moment of failure" (Inlander). The method behind this is simple. Kasavin asked "What would these characters talk about and what would they notice? Add those interactions," and called the reactive dialogue "a simple system at heart, we just kept adding more types of conditions to check against." He also admits "we didn't have any visualization of the event connections" (GameSpot). For a modular, data-driven codebase, that is a ready-made spec: **hub lines as data rows with explicit conditions** (who was rescued, who went down, which boss, which ally saved whom), kept visible from day one. Moonlighter's town fills up but "you can't learn much about these shopkeepers" (RPG Site), which shows the cost of skipping this: residents with no reactive lines become vending machines.

Writing cost can stay low with the right template. Suikoden II recruits mostly through short one-task side quests (PlayStation LifeStyle), and Dragon Quest Builders 2 residents liven up the town with small requests, complaining when one like a toilet is ignored (USgamer). Spiritfarer's NPCs were written almost entirely by one writer, whose guideline was "just to write what you think is fun." Its tonal rule was **"10-15% dramatic as opposed to 85-90% whimsical,"** because "a sombre moment can only be real if it happens for a short amount of time" (Pocket Tactics). That ratio fits Redwall-style warmth. XCOM 2 adds a near-free technique: letting players name and customise characters so they build the attachment themselves (Wikipedia: XCOM 2).

Mouse Guard offers a structure that fits the loop closely. Play alternates a GM's Turn, where trouble lands on the patrol, with a Players' Turn, where checks earned during the mission are spent on the players' own goals. A GM summarised it as "The Player Turn is not downtime but the chance for the players to drive the game forward on their terms!" Seasons then close with a Winter phase at Lockhaven, where promotions happen (Adept Play). Mapped onto this game, the mission is the GM's Turn, the abbey visit is the Players' Turn, and a season-end "Winter at the abbey" marks each arc with promotions and a visible jump in the stronghold. The Guard's creed, "never put yourself before others" (SU&SD), states the project's theme almost word for word.

Five failure modes recur across fifteen games

The criticisms cluster tightly. First, **currency sprawl**: Hades II critics reportedly felt they "must juggle ashes, psyche, moon dust, bones, and numerous collectible resources," with runs becoming "obligatory farming missions" (EnterpriseAM). Absolum runs three meta currencies plus Radiance (Rogueliker). Second, **required power grind**: Absolum's permanent upgrades feel dated because "you won't survive unless you max these out" (Punished Backlog). Nintendo Life warns of "repetition and grind" in its first five hours (Nintendo Life). Children of Morta has a "tiresome early grind" (Wireframe), and Rogue Legacy 2 "a steep grind to get a lot of the good stuff" (GodisaGeek). Dead Cells is the counterexample. Its permanent unlocks open paths and options, and Sébastien Bénard chose "more impactful items" so that "most runs should be viable" (MCV/Develop).

Third, **a base that competes with the missions**. Cult of the Lamb's clock keeps running during crusades, so the cult can fall apart and force "an early return even during strong runs" (Indiecator). Ni no Kuni II's kingdom is "the one element that ever disrupts Revenant Kingdom's pacing" because the story stalls until resource requirements are met (Easy Allies). Fire Emblem: Three Houses loses an "hour or so" to housekeeping (VGC). Fourth, **chores that undercut warmth**. Winter Burrow's kindness themes are undercut because crafting mostly refills survival meters (Checkpoint Gaming). Tails of Iron 2's rebuild side quests "become formulaic" (Checkpoint Gaming). Spiritfarer's developers cut seasonal transitions and shrank farming after IGN called the tasks repetitive (Wikipedia: Spiritfarer). Fifth, **unforgiving rosters**. Suikoden II's missable recruits plus a best-ending requirement make it "very unforgiving" (PlayStation LifeStyle). Children of Morta's fatigue meter, which forces you to rotate heroes, "goes a little too far" (Geeky Hobbies).

A subtler lesson: Darkest Dungeon II's developers rebuilt their between-runs layer because the original "didn't afford players any real choice" (Epic Games Store). A short hub visit is good, but an empty one isn't. Each visit should contain at least one real decision, such as what to build next, who comes along or which rescue to chase.

On the mission side, Dragon's Crown dropped random dungeon generation "so players could learn and master each layout," then reused each stage through a second path and quests that send you back (Wikipedia: Dragon's Crown; Game Informer). Repetition is still its most common criticism, so a revisited stage needs a real change: a different objective, enemy mix or captive. Run lengths in the genre sit at **about 15 minutes early, up to 30 later** for Absolum (Nintendo Life), and Children of Morta runs "rarely take more than 30 minutes" (Wireframe). No source measured hub minutes per visit, so the advice to keep the hub to a few minutes is inferred from praise and complaints, not measured.

Helpers should fill roles and survive bosses

Documented AI companions are useful because they are limited. Monster Hunter Rise lets a solo hunter bring two buddies but each multiplayer hunter only one, and gives them named roles (Healer, Assist, Fight, Bombardier, Gathering) instead of making them second hunters (Fextralife). That "fewer helpers as more humans join" rule fits

the 1–3 hero cap directly. Dragon's Crown shows how allies fail: its resurrected bone-pile allies help early, but "the further you play, the less helpful AI becomes," and against bosses they end up "getting torn to shreds" by screen-wide attacks (Siliconera). Paying to revive and re-picking allies on every town visit was called tedious in the same review. That makes two design rules: allies must step out of telegraphed danger zones, and the party must persist between missions without upkeep. River City Girls 2 offers a cheaper fallback, where recruited former enemies return as cooldown-based assist calls, two chosen at home (DualShockers). That works well for rescued folk who aren't full adventurers.

The project's starting helping verbs already match the genre. TMNT: Shredder's Revenge uses a timed hold-to-revive and a high five that gives a partner two health (Co-Optimus). George Kamitani described Dragon's Crown teamwork as "replenishing the health of an ally near death" (Siliconera interview). Player count needs restraint. Absolum caps co-op at two for readability given its on-screen effects (Nintendo Wire). Six-player TMNT gets "very chaotic," and Dragon's Crown effects "often obscured the characters" (Wikipedia: Dragon's Crown). Scaling also needs testing in both directions: Children of Morta's reviewer found dungeons "actually easier with one player" (Geeky Hobbies). Children of Morta's family-wide passives, unlocked by levelling any one hero, keep benched characters relevant without forcing rotation. Kamitani's "escape route" bosses (a collapsible bridge to drop a dragon) and Absolum's help-after-repeated-deaths "Mother's Guidance" are cheap ways to soften difficulty (Rogueliker).

For gear, the arcade end of the genre stays light. Castle Crashers' animal orbs float beside you with one clear effect each, such as a stat bump, a pecking attack or slow healing (Castle Crashers wiki). That is a natural "familiar" slot for an animal world. Dragon's Crown shows rank and type for free and charges to reveal stats, but players "generally lose more money on the appraisal than you gain" (Game Informer), so keep the end-of-stage keep/sell decision and drop the fee. Absolum shows the opposite risk: if build choices barely matter, gear feels pointless ("the impact of your decisions on your build just doesn't feel as pronounced") (Rogueliker). Fewer items with stronger effects is the Dead Cells lesson again.

Animal-world peers leave the warm, heroic lane open

Rebuilding a home is a common thread in this genre. Tails of Iron's Redgi fights "to rescue his brothers and rebuild his kingdom" (Well Played). Tails of Iron 2 rebuilds Winter's Edge with some upgrades required to progress. Winter Burrow restores an ancestral stump home. Cult of the Lamb feeds its base from dungeon runs. Players clearly understand a rescue-and-rebuild premise. The tone is where the gap lies. Odd Bug Studio aims for "that cute but creepy feeling" with "very visually brutal executions," and Tails of Iron 2 has a "grim, epic feel" (Checkpoint Gaming). Cult of the Lamb is "adorably sinister" (HPPR/NPR), and Spiritfarer is a "cozy management game about dying" (GamesBeat). The sincere heroic example is Mouse Guard, whose "sincere feel-goodness is infectious" and whose scarred characters remain "a force for good" (SU&SD). Warmth with real stakes, such as captives taken and a vermin threat, is distinct in action games. It still needs stakes, though: the licensed Lost Legends of Redwall: The Scout was faulted for "almost no serious storylines" and flat delivery (KeenGamer).

Demand is real but follows loops more than licences. Cult of the Lamb sold a million copies in a week (HPPR/NPR), and Spiritfarer passed a million in about a year (GamesBeat). The official Redwall games stayed small and reviewed modestly. Two combat warnings from Tails of Iron 2 apply directly to a belt-scroller: a moveset that "stops evolving after mid-game," and frustrating flying or teleporting enemies that keep their distance. Ghost of a Tale makes its mouse heroic by moving through a world "not made to his size" (80.lv). In a brawler, that means human-scale props as set dressing and the occasional giant-predator boss, with regular vermin kept near hero size so fights stay readable. One gap stands out: no sourced video game in this set makes *teamwork itself* the heroic act, which is

exactly what this project's hook proposes. Everdell, Armello, Tunic, Mice and Mystics and Moonstone were not researched, so this comparison is incomplete.

Prioritized recommendations for Cloak & Claw

#	Recommendation	Why (precedent)
1	**No home timers, ever.** Nothing decays, ticks down or needs maintenance while on a mission, and the next mission is never gated on stockpiling.	Cult of the Lamb forced early returns; Ni no Kuni II's resource gates were its most-cited complaint
2	**Every rescue gives one visible change *and* one playable change.** A standee appears near a building slot, and something new unlocks: a vendor, an assist, a move, an ally.	Moonlighter's town fill-in; Winter Burrow shows meters alone feel empty
3	**Roughly 1 adventurer per 3–4 rescues;** the rest become services or village-wide passives.	Suikoden's 108 recruits vs ~6 slots; Ni no Kuni II staff
4	**Bastion-style 1:1 rebuild.** Each mission's main rescue restores one fixed building slot (ruined sprite -> restored sprite), run by the rescued character ("Bramble's forge"). Add Suikoden-style staged jumps (gate, banner, bell) at recruit-count thresholds.	Bastion cores; Darkest Dungeon repaint; Suikoden HQ levels
5	**One building currency + gear drops.** Rescued folk *are* the second "currency"; avoid ores, flora and multiple meta tokens.	Hades II and Absolum currency complaints
6	**Options over stats.** Stat boosts are rare, small, village-wide and framed as accessibility. The first mission must be fun with zero upgrades.	Dead Cells "most runs viable"; Absolum "max these out"
7	**Small fixed gear set:** weapon + one ring (+ an optional familiar slot later). Show what an item does immediately; sort keep/sell at the stage end with no appraisal fee.	Castle Crashers orbs; Dragon's Crown appraisal tax
8	**AI allies with one role each** (brawler, medic, thrower). Fewer AI allies as more humans join (cap 3 total). First AI rule: leave telegraphed danger zones.	Monster Hunter buddies; Dragon's Crown boss shredding
9	**The party persists without upkeep.** Downed allies wake up at home for free; no re-pick or revive fee. Benched adventurers patrol and bring back a little currency or a rumor.	Dragon's Crown tedium; Darkest Dungeon II "real choice"
10	**Reactive hub barks as data rows with conditions** (rescued X, Y went down, Z revived you, boss hit). Write a few per resident; give deep personal quests to ~10–20%.	Kasavin's condition system; Moonlighter's thin shopkeepers
11	**Pacing:** 10–20 min missions, a hub visit of a few minutes in one walkable room with one real decision; a "Winter at the abbey" season close every 4–6 missions with promotions and a big rebuild beat.	Absolum/CoM run lengths; Mouse Guard Winter phase
12	**Never permanently missable rescues;** a rumor board at the abbey points to anyone skipped.	Suikoden II "very unforgiving"
13	**Reuse stages Dragon's Crown-style** (second path, new captive or objective), and make every revisit change something real.	Dragon's Crown learnable layouts vs repetition
14	**Tone: ~85% whimsical, short earned sad beats,** real stakes (captives, vermin), heroism through teamwork; keep the moveset growing past mid-game through allies and helping verbs.	Spiritfarer ratio; Mouse Guard creed; Tails of Iron 2 static moveset
15	**Help-after-defeats safety net** (a Mother Abbess blessing after repeated wipes) and boss "escape routes."	Absolum Mother's Guidance; Kamitani's bridges

What the hub should *not* be: a free-placement builder, a survival-meter sim, a second minigame (Moonlighter's shop, Cult of the Lamb's farming), a place with re-pick or revive fees, or a list of menus with no faces.

Open questions for the designer

How large is the full cast of rescues: closer to 12 named folk, or 30 or more with templated minor ones? Is a mission a fixed hand-made stage (Dragon's Crown) or a short branching run (Absolum), and does a failed mission still bring a rescued captive home? Do co-op heroes share one abbey and progression, or does each player keep their own, as in Absolum? Should rescued adventurers be able to fall for good in a mission, or always come home (warmer, and closer to Spiritfarer's view that departures should be rare and earned)? Does the theme extend to *who* gets rescued, with former vermin or neutral folk persuaded to join as in River City Girls 2? And how far should "helping" go as a combat verb beyond revive and potion toss: shielding, carrying a captive out under fire, team-up throws?

Conclusion

The research turns the project's hook from a theme into a design constraint. If the game is about folk who stopped helping each other, then the hub cannot ask for upkeep, the allies cannot be fodder, and the currencies cannot turn rescues into farming. Each of those would make the systems contradict the story, which is the Winter Burrow failure. Absolum shows that beat 'em up players accept the roguelite loop but notice when the home is only a shop. The opening for this project is to make the home's warmth the main reward and to keep its mechanics deliberately thin.

The cheapest high-value investment is not art but a condition-driven dialogue table and a fixed set of ruined/restored building slots. Hades, Bastion and Darkest Dungeon all show these give most of the felt progress for little production cost, and both fit a modular, data-file codebase. The largest unresolved risk is AI allies in boss fights. No source documented how any studio tuned ally strength, so this needs early prototyping rather than research.